The Woman by the River

Two worlds collide, quietly, at the water's edge

Yara is seventeen, half human and half Vey'kar, and she leads the east trail now, by the village's word. This morning she goes to the river with Amara to gather herbs — and finds a human woman, hurt and alone, who hates the wire snares as much as she does.

Daughter of Two Worlds was written by BiomassFlood, with AI assistance from Luna for drafting and editing. All characters, worldbuilding, and story decisions are the author's own original work.

CHAPTER 6

A BIGGER VILLAGE

The morning after Yara was given the east trail, Kijani woke up bigger.

That was the first thing Yara noticed, and the second thing she noticed was that nobody else seemed surprised by it, which surprised her most of all. She came out of her shelter with the bone charm tucked safe at her belt, and the village was already moving, and there were new voices in the clearing, and new shelters going up at the edge of the trees, and a family she had never seen before, unloading packs by the river path, and a small boy, no older than six, chasing a chicken that did not belong to anyone, and laughing like the world had never had a snare in it.

“More of us,” Zola said, appearing at Yara’s elbow the way she always did, sudden and warm and a little bit out of breath, and her grin was wide, though Yara could see the worry underneath it, the way she always could with Zola. “They came in on the river trail at dawn. A whole family, from the far side of the ridge. Oya says there will be more. She says the word is going out, in the old way, from hunter to hunter, that there is a village here, and a queen here, and a place to be safe.”

Yara nodded, and she felt the pride in her chest stand up a little straighter, and then the weight that came with it, because more people meant more mouths, and more trails, and more chances for a man with snares to find them.

“More of us to hide,” Zola said, bumping Yara’s shoulder with her own, companionable and warm, “and more of us to do the hiding. It is not only you. You are only the one who leads it.”

At the fire, Amara was already packing her satchel, and when she saw Yara she waved her over, and her eyes were kind, and tired, and steady, the way they always were in the morning, when the day had not yet asked anything of her.

“Yara,” Amara said, and her voice was calm, and patient, and it settled Yara the way the river settled the village, low and steady and always there. “I need herbs from the river bank, the ones that only grow where the water is slow. The new family has a child with a cough, and the old woman’s hands are worse, and I am running low. Will you come with me? Two pairs of hands are better than one, and two pairs of eyes are better than one, and I would like the company.”

Yara nodded, and she felt the relief in her chest loosen a little, because a morning with Amara, gathering herbs by the river, was an ordinary morning, and after two nights of snares and coughs in the dark, an ordinary morning felt like a gift.

“I will come,” she said, and she picked up her own satchel, and her knife, and her cloak, and she did not take her spear, because Amara did not take a spear, and because a gathering morning was not a hunting morning, and she wanted, just for a morning, to be a girl gathering herbs with her mentor, and not a leader walking a trail where a man set snares.

They walked to the river in the slow, easy way Amara always walked, stopping to look at things, and to smell things, and to teach things, and Yara listened, and learned, and breathed, and for a while the village, and the snares, and the man in the trees, all felt very far away, the way a storm feels far away when you are standing in the sun.

“This one,” Amara said, crouching by the water’s edge, her fingers gentle on a low green plant, “is for coughs. And this one, the one with the bitter leaf, is for fevers.”

Yara laughed, quietly, because Amara was the only adult who would say a thing like that out loud, and then she heard it: a sound, from further down the river bank, where the trees grew thick, and the water ran slow.

It was a human sound. A cry, short and sharp, and then a gasp, and then silence, and then, very faintly, a voice, speaking in a language Yara knew, because her father had taught it to her when she was small, and because it was the language of the human world: English, and under it, another language, softer and quicker,

that Yara did not know, but that sounded, somehow, like a song.

“Amara,” Yara said, and her voice was low, and her markings flared, bright and blue, before she could stop them, and she breathed them down again, slow and steady. “Did you hear that?”

Amara was already standing, her satchel in her hand, her eyes on the trees, and her face was calm, and alert, and afraid, all at once, the way a healer’s face goes when someone is hurt and she does not yet know how hurt they are.

“I heard it,” Amara said, quietly, so that it was for Yara and not for the river. “A human. Down by the water. And hurt, I think. Stay behind me, Yara. And keep your markings down. And do not speak unless I speak to you first. Do you understand me?”

Yara nodded, and her throat was tight, and her heart was beating hard enough that she could feel it in her teeth, and she understood, with a clarity that frightened her, that the two worlds she had always lived between were about to meet, right here, at the water’s edge, and that she was going to have to choose, in a moment, which one she would stand in.

A CRY BY THE RIVER

The woman was lying half in the water and half out of it, at the bottom of a short, steep bank, where the river had cut the earth away, and she had slipped, and fallen, and not been able to get up again.

She was human, Yara saw at once, and young, not much older than Yara herself, though to Yara, who had grown up among hunters who were six and a half feet tall, she looked small, and soft, and breakable, and very, very far from home.

She had warm brown skin, and dark curly hair pulled back in a ponytail, with a pencil stuck in it, and she was wearing practical field clothes: boots, cargo pants, and a faded vest with too many pockets, a notebook in one hand and a camera in the other, and a scar on her knee, pale and old.

Her ankle was twisted under her, at a wrong angle, and her face was pale, and her eyes were wide, and she was trying very hard not to cry, and failing, just a little, at the edges, the way brave people do when they are hurt and alone and do not want to be a burden.

“Hello?” the woman said, and her voice was shaky, and kind, and curious, all at once, and she looked up at Amara, and then at Yara, and her eyes went wider still, because she could see, even through the cloak, even through the dimmed markings, that Yara was not quite human, and not quite anything she had ever seen before. “Oh, thank goodness. I fell. I was following the river, and I slipped, and my ankle —” she stopped, and swallowed, and tried again, slower, “— my ankle is not doing what ankles are supposed to do. I am Elena. Elena Ruiz. I am a researcher. I study animals. I am not —” she laughed, a small, shaky laugh, “— I am not a poacher, if that is what you are thinking. I hate poachers. I am here to stop them, not to be one.”

Amara crouched down beside her, slow and calm, the way she crouched beside anyone who was hurt, and her hands were gentle, and her voice was gentle, and Yara watched her, and learned, the way she always did when Amara was healing.

“I am Amara,” Amara said, and her voice was level, and kind, and it settled the woman the way it settled everyone. “And this is Yara. We are —” she paused, and Yara could see her choosing her words, carefully, the way she chose herbs, “— we live upriver. We know this jungle. Let me look at your ankle, Elena Ruiz, and then we will see.”

Elena nodded, and her eyes were still wide, and she was still looking at Yara, and Yara could feel her looking, and could feel her own markings prickling under her cloak, and she breathed, slow, and breathed them down again, until they were only a faint, blue shimmer, easy to miss, easy to mistake for light through leaves.

“You are —” Elena began, and then she stopped, and shook her head, and smiled, a small, brave smile, though her ankle must have been hurting very badly. “You are very tall. And your eyes are —” she stopped

again, and laughed, softly, "— your eyes are very gold. I have never seen eyes like that. Are you — are you from around here?"

"I am from upriver," Yara said, and her voice came out steadier than she felt, and she was proud of that, and frightened by it, both at once. "My family hunts here. We know the river. We know the trails. You should not be out here alone, Elena Ruiz. The river bank is steep here, and the jungle is not kind to people who walk it alone."

"I know," Elena said, and her smile faded, and her face went serious, and sad, and angry, all at once, and Yara recognised the anger, because it was the same anger she felt when she thought about the snares. "I know. I was following a line of wire snares. Someone has been setting them, all along the river, and I was trying to find who, and to take them down, and I slipped. I hate snares. I hate what they do. I lost —" she stopped, and her voice went quiet, and her eyes went far away, to a place Yara could not see, "— I lost someone I worked with, once, to people like that. To poachers. So I do not walk past snares. Not any more. Not ever."

Yara felt her breath catch, and then settle, and something in her chest stood up straighter, because this human, this stranger, this woman lying half in the river with a twisted ankle, hated the same thing Yara hated, and had lost someone to it, the way Jabari had lost someone to humans, and the way Yara might lose someone, if the man with the snares kept coming back.

"Then we will help you," Yara said, and she said it before Amara could speak, and before she could think about whether it was wise, or whether it was allowed, or whether it was what a leader was supposed to do, and she said it because it was true, and because it was the only thing she could say, and mean it. "We will help you, Elena Ruiz. That is what we do."

THE POULTICE

Amara looked at Yara for a long moment, and Yara could see the warning in her eyes, and the pride in her eyes, both at once, and then Amara nodded, once, slow and certain, and turned back to Elena's ankle, and her hands were gentle, and her voice was gentle, and Yara understood that Amara had just made a choice too, and that the choice was the same as hers.

"Hold still," Amara said, and her fingers were careful on Elena's ankle, feeling the bones, and the swelling, and the heat, and her face was calm, and focused, the way it always was when she was healing. "It is not broken, I think. It is twisted, and swollen, and it will hurt for a while, but it is not broken. Yara, the bitter leaf. The one for swelling. Chew it, and make a poultice, and bring it to me."

Yara nodded, and she went to the plants they had been gathering, and her hands were shaking, just a little, and she made them steady, the way Amara had taught her, by breathing, slow, and by thinking about the work, and not about the fear, and she chewed the bitter leaf, and made the poultice, and brought it back, and Amara spread it on Elena's ankle, and bound it with a strip of cloth from her satchel, neat and tight and kind.

"There," Amara said, and she sat back on her heels, and wiped her hands on her skirt, and her voice was level, and carrying, the way it was when she was giving an order, or a warning, or both at once. "That will help the swelling. But you cannot walk on it, Elena Ruiz. Not today. Not alone. You will have to wait, and rest, and let it settle, and then someone will have to help you back to the path."

"I cannot stay here," Elena said, shaky and stubborn and brave all at once. "I have to get back. My team will worry. And the snares are still out there. Someone has to take them down. If I do not, who will?"

"We will," Yara said, and her voice was steady, and it was her voice, and it was also, she realised, her mother's voice, the way Oya's voice sounded when she gave an order she wished she did not have to give. "We take them down. We have been taking them down. The wire, the snares, all of it. We do not leave them in our jungle."

Elena looked at her, and her eyes were wide, and her face was pale, and she was quiet for a long moment, and Yara could see her thinking, and putting things together, the way Yara herself put things together

when she read a trail: a girl with gold eyes, and faint blue markings, and a healer who knew herbs no human healer knew, and a village that did not exist on any map, and snares that kept disappearing, and a man with a camera who kept coming back to read his line.

"You take them down," Elena said, slowly, and her voice was soft, and wondering, and a little bit afraid, all at once. "You are the ones taking them down. I have been finding empty gullies, and cut wire, and marks on trees that I could not read, and I thought —" she stopped, and laughed, a small, shaky laugh, "— I thought I was going mad. I thought the jungle was taking its own snares down. But it was you. It was you, all along."

Yara felt her throat go tight, and her markings flare, bright and blue, before she could stop them, and she breathed them down again, slow and steady, and she looked at Amara, and Amara looked at her, and Amara nodded, once, very slightly, and Yara understood that the secret was already out, or half out, or out enough that pretending would only make it worse.

"We take them down," Yara said, quietly, so that it was for Elena and not for the river, and not for the jungle. "Because they are in our home. And because they hurt animals that have done nothing wrong. And because the man who sets them will not stop, unless someone stops him. Do you understand me, Elena Ruiz?"

"I understand," Elena said, and her voice was steady now, and her eyes were steady, and she reached out, and laid her hand over Yara's hand, warm and human, and shaking, just a little, the way brave hands sometimes shake. "I understand. And I will keep your secret. I do not report people, Yara. I report animals. And I protect the jungle. That is what I do. If you are part of the jungle, then I protect you too."

A NAME, AND A SKETCH

They stayed with Elena until the sun was high, and the river was bright, and her ankle had settled enough that she could stand, with help, and hobble, with help, and Yara and Amara walked her back to the human path, slowly, one step at a time, and Yara felt, with every step, the two worlds she lived between pulling at her, one in each hand, and she did not know which one to follow, and she followed both, because she did not know how to do anything else.

On the way, Elena talked, and Yara listened, and learned, the way she always did when someone talked about the human world, hungrily, and carefully, and with her whole body.

"I know the man who sets the snares," Elena said, and her voice was low, and angry, and sad, all at once, and Yara recognised the anger, because it was the same anger she felt when she thought about the man in the trees. "I know him. His name is Dane. Dane Mercer. He is a trophy hunter. He has a camera, and a rifle, and a notebook, and he thinks he is the only person in this jungle who knows how to read a trail. He is wrong. He is very, very wrong. But he is patient, and he is greedy, and he will not stop until he has proof of whatever he thinks he has found."

Yara went very still. Her whole body went still, the way a hunted animal goes still, and then, a heartbeat later, the way a hunter goes still, and she felt her markings flare, bright and blue, and she breathed them down again, slow and steady, and she said, very carefully, "Dane Mercer. That is his name?"

"That is his name," Elena said, and she looked at Yara, and her eyes were serious, and sad, and she nodded, once, slow and certain. "And I hate what he does. I have hated it for years. He thinks the jungle is a shop, and the animals are things to buy and sell. He is not a hunter, Yara. A hunter respects what he hunts. Dane does not respect anything. He only wants."

Yara nodded, her throat tight, thinking of the boot print, and the kneeling place, and the cough in the dark. Now the man had a name, and the name made him smaller, somehow, and bigger, both at once: smaller, because a man with a name is a man, and not a shadow, and bigger, because a man with a name is a man who will come back.

"Thank you," Yara said, quietly, so that it was for Elena and not for the path, and not for the jungle. "Thank you for telling me his name. And thank you for hating what he does. That is —" she stopped, and

smiled, a small, tired smile, "— that is more than most humans would do."

At the human path, Elena stopped, and turned, and looked back at Yara, and at Amara, and her eyes were wide, and her face was pale, and she was quiet for a long moment, and Yara could see her thinking, and putting things together, and then she reached into her vest, and took out a small, worn notebook, and tore out a page, and held it out to Yara.

"Here," Elena said, and her voice was soft, and steady, and brave, all at once. "This is for you. It is a sketch I made, of a footprint I found, by the river, two days ago. It is too big to be human. Too big, and too deep, and the toes are wrong. I did not know what it was. I still do not know what it was. But I think —" she stopped, and laughed, a small, shaky laugh, "— I think you might know. And I think, if you ever need a human who knows how Dane thinks, and how to stall him, and how to make a trail disappear on a map, then you know where to find me. I will be on the river. I will always be on the river."

Yara took the page, and looked at it, and her breath caught, because the sketch was good, and true, and it was a Vey'kar footprint, unmistakably, big and deep and wrong-toed, and Elena had drawn it carefully, and kindly, and without fear, and she had given it to Yara, as a gift, and as a promise, both at once.

"I will keep it," Yara said, and her voice was steady, and it was her voice, and it was also, she realised, her father's voice, the way she remembered it from when she was seven: quiet, and curious, and brave in a quiet way. "And I will remember. Thank you, Elena Ruiz."

Elena nodded, and turned, and hobbled away down the human path, slowly, one step at a time, and Yara watched her go, until she was gone, and the path was empty, and the jungle was quiet, and the river was bright, and the morning was ordinary again, except that it was not ordinary at all, and never would be again.

A FRIEND, OR A RISK?

Zola was waiting for them at the edge of the clearing, when they came home, and she was not waiting patiently at all. She was pacing a short, worn track in the dust, three steps one way and three steps back, her spear tapping against her shoulder with every turn, and when she saw Yara she stopped dead, and her eyes went wide, and her markings flared, bright and blue, and her voice, when she spoke, was loud enough for the whole clearing to hear.

"Where have you been?" Zola said, and her voice was angry, and frightened, and relieved, all at once, and Yara recognised all three, because she felt all three herself. "You went to gather herbs, and you have been gone all morning, and nobody knew where you were, and I was beginning to think the man with the snares had taken you, and I was about to go after you, and I was about to —" she stopped, and her eyes went to the page in Yara's hand, and to the sketch on it, and her voice went quieter, and colder, and more afraid. "What is that? Yara. What is that, and where did you get it?"

Yara took a breath, slow, and let it out, slow, and told her. She told her about the cry by the river, and the woman in the water, and the twisted ankle, and the poultice, and the snares, and the name, Dane Mercer, and the sketch, and the promise, and as she spoke she watched Zola's face do something it almost never did: it went still, and then it went angry, and then it went afraid, and then it went still again, like a hand closing around a wound.

"A human," Zola said, and her voice was flat, and cold, and it cut across the clearing like a blade. "You brought a human to our river, and you told her about the snares, and you told her about us, and you gave her our secret, and you let her walk away with a sketch of our footprint in her hand. Tell me, Yara. Is that leading, or is that hoping? Is that compassion, or is that the human in you, getting us all killed?"

The clearing went very slightly quiet, and Yara felt her temper flare, hot and sudden, the way it always did when someone insulted her mother, or her people, or her, and her markings flared with it, bright and blue, and she breathed, slow, and let the feeling be there without feeding it, the way Amara had taught her, and the way Jabari himself had taught her, on the training ground, when he had said to think, and not to burn.

“It is compassion,” Yara said, and her voice was level, and her hands were still at her sides, and she looked at Zola, and did not look away. “She was hurt, and alone, and she hates the snares, and she hates the man who sets them, and she knows his name, and she knows how he thinks, and she promised to keep our secret, and I believe her. I believe her, Zola, because I looked in her eyes, and I saw that she meant it. And if I am wrong, then I am wrong, and I will answer for it. But I would rather be wrong for helping, than right for walking past a hurt woman by a river.”

Zola looked at her for a long moment, her old friend’s eyes level and bright, and Yara made herself meet them, and not look away, and not dim her markings, and not shrink, and then, slowly, Zola’s shoulders dropped, and her spear lowered, and her face softened, and she laughed, very quietly, in the clearing, where everyone could hear it.

“You are a terrible leader,” Zola said, fond and teasing and relieved all at once, “who helps humans by rivers and believes their promises.”

“Tell her,” Yara said, laughing quietly, because it was true, and because it frightened her a little, and steadied her too. “Tell her I brought home a name, and a promise, and a friend, instead. Tell her that is what leading is.”

But Zola’s laugh faded, and her face went serious again, and she looked at Yara, and her eyes were afraid, and she said, quietly, so that only Yara could hear, “Yara. If Jabari hears about this, he will use it. He will say you bring humans to our door. He will say you are too human to lead. You know he will.”

“I know,” Yara said, and her voice was steady, and her throat was tight, and she nodded, once, slow and certain. “I know he will. And I will answer him, when he does. That is what leading is, too.”

THE QUEEN'S WORD

Oya was standing on the temple steps when Yara came to her, and her face was calm, and level, and afraid, all at once, and Yara understood, without being told, that Zola had already told her, or that Amara had already told her, or that a mother simply knows, the way mothers do, when her daughter has done something brave, and something dangerous, both at once.

“Tell me,” Oya said, and her voice was level, and carrying, and it settled over the clearing like a hand settling over a fire. “Tell me what happened by the river, Yara. All of it. Do not leave anything out. Not the ankle. Not the snares. Not the name. Not the sketch. All of it.”

Yara told her. She told her about the cry, and the woman in the water, and the twisted ankle, and the poultice, and the snares, and the name, Dane Mercer, and the sketch, and the promise, and as she spoke she watched her mother’s face, and she saw, in her mother’s face, the thing she had been afraid she would see: fear, and anger, and pride, all at once, and under them, slower and steadier, something she recognised now: love, and the weight of it, both at once.

“A human,” Oya said, and her voice was flat, and cold, and it cut across the clearing like a blade. “You helped a human, by our river, and you let her walk away with a sketch of our footprint. Tell me, Yara. Is that leading, or is that the human in you, getting us all killed?”

Yara felt her temper flare, hot and sudden, and her markings flared with it, bright and blue, and she breathed, slow, and let the feeling be there without feeding it, and she looked at her mother, and did not look away.

“It is leading,” she said, and her voice was level, and her hands were still at her sides. “She was hurt, and alone, and she hates the snares, and she knows his name, and she knows how he thinks, and she promised to keep our secret, and I believe her. And if I am wrong, then I am wrong, and I will answer for it. But I would rather be wrong for helping, than right for walking past a hurt woman by a river. That is what you taught me, Mother. That is what a queen does. That is what you did, at the fire, when you kept the village calm. You did the other half of leading. I did the other half too.”

Oya was quiet for a long moment, and Yara watched her mother's face do something it almost never did in front of the village: it softened, and then it hurt, and then it steadied itself again, like a hand closing around a wound, and then, slowly, Oya nodded, once, slow and certain.

"She stays away from the east trail," Oya said, and her voice was level, and carrying, and it settled over the village like a hand settling over a fire. "That is the order. She does not come to Kijani. She does not walk our trails. She does not tell anyone what she saw. And you do not meet her again, Yara, unless I say so. Is that understood?"

"Yes," Yara said, and her chin was up, and her hands were pressed flat against her thighs to keep them still, and she nodded, once, slow and certain. "Yes, Mother. I understand."

"And Yara," Oya said, and her voice went quieter, so that it was for Yara and not for the steps, and her hand hovered a breath from Yara's arm without quite touching. "You did the right thing. Do not let anyone tell you otherwise. Not Jabari. Not Zola. Not even me, when I am afraid. You did the right thing."

Yara felt her breath catch, and then settle, and something in her chest stood up straighter, and then sat down again, because the words were a gift, and they were also a question, and she did not know which one they were yet, and she nodded, and her throat was too tight to speak, and her markings were bright, and she did not try to dim them, because her mother was her mother, and she did not have to hide from her mother, and for a moment, standing on the temple steps in the daylight, she felt like she belonged, fully, in both of her worlds at once, and it did not tear her in two.

LET THE TRIAL DECIDE

Jabari heard about it before the sun went down. Yara knew he would. Zola had warned her, and Oya had warned her, and the village was small, and news travelled in a village the way smoke travels in a jungle: quickly, and everywhere, and with no one quite knowing where it had started.

He came to the fire that evening, and he stood at the edge of the steps, and his face was cold, and his voice was cold, and it carried across the whole clearing, and Yara felt every eye turn towards her, and her markings flared, bright and blue, before she could stop them.

"So," Jabari said, and his voice was flat, and it cut across the clearing like a blade. "The princess brings humans to our river. She helps them, and she believes their promises, and she calls it leading. Tell me, Oya. Is that a princess, or is that a girl who does not know what she is?"

The clearing went very slightly quiet, and Yara felt her temper flare, hot and sudden, and she breathed, slow, and let the feeling be there without feeding it, and she looked at Jabari, and did not look away, and she said, very quietly, so that it was for him and not for the clearing, "It is a princess who helps a hurt woman by a river, Jabari. It is a princess who brings home a name, and a promise, and a friend, instead of a body, and a secret, and a war. That is what a princess does. That is what I do."

Jabari looked at her for a long moment, his old eyes level and wintry, and Yara made herself meet them, and not look away, and not dim her markings, and not shrink, and then, slowly, the elder nodded, once, the way he had nodded on the training ground, and on the east trail, when she had passed his test by letting a feeling be there without feeding it.

"Then let the trial decide what she is," Jabari said, and he said it to Oya, and to the village, and not to Yara, and that, Yara understood, was the point: he was not praising her to her face, he was telling the village, so that the village would hear it. "A trial makes a hunter. That is the law. That is the old way. Let her prove herself, alone, in the jungle, the way a hunter proves herself, and then we will know what she is. Human, or hunter, or something in between, that does not yet have a name."

Oya was quiet for a long moment, and Yara watched her mother's face, and saw, in her mother's face, the fear, and the pride, and the love, all at once, and then Oya nodded, once, slow and certain, and her voice, when she spoke, was level, and carrying, and it settled over the village like a hand settling over a fire.

“Then let the trial be announced,” Oya said, and her voice was steady, and it was her voice, and it was also, Yara realised, her mother’s voice, the way Oya’s voice sounded when she gave an order she wished she did not have to give. “In three days, at the fire, I will announce Yara’s trial. And Jabari will set it, as is the old way, and as is his right as elder. And Yara will face it, as is her right as princess, and as is her duty as heir.”

Three days. The words hung in the clearing, and Yara felt them land in her chest, heavy and bright at once, and she looked at Oya, and Oya looked at her, and Oya’s face did something it almost never did in front of the village: it softened, and it was proud, and it was afraid, both at once, and she nodded, once, slow and certain.

“Three days,” Yara said, and her voice was steady, and her chin was up, and her hands were pressed flat against her thighs to keep them still. “I will be ready.”

Amara, sitting by the fire, looked at Yara, and her eyes were kind, and sad, and steady, and she nodded, once, very slightly, and Yara understood that Amara had just made a choice too, and that the choice was the same as hers: to help, and to keep the secret, and to believe, even when believing was hard.

THREE DAYS

That night, Yara sat in her shelter, alone, with the sketch in her hand, and looked at it in the dark, and thought about everything that had happened, and everything that was going to happen, and she felt, with a clarity that frightened her, that her life had changed, in a morning, by a river, and that it would never be the same again.

She had met a human, and the human had not been a monster, or a poacher, or a threat, but a woman with a twisted ankle, and a notebook, and a promise, and a name, and a sketch, and Yara had helped her, and believed her.

And now there was a trial, in three days, and Jabari would set it, and it would be hard, because Jabari wanted it to be hard, and Yara would have to face it, alone, in the jungle, and prove herself, not as a human, and not as a hunter, but as Yara, both at once.

In her shelter, she took the bone charm from her belt, and held it in her hand, and looked at it in the dark, and felt it hum, once, low and warm, the way it had hummed on the night of the second chapter, and on the night of the fifth, and she thought about what her mother had promised her: one true thing, when the east trail was hers by daylight too.

It was hers now, she thought, and her markings flared, bright and gold, and she breathed them down again, slow and steady. It was hers by dark, and it was hers by the village’s word, and it was hers by Jabari’s word, and now there was a trial, and a human, and a name, Dane Mercer, and a promise, Elena Ruiz, and all of it was hers to carry, and she would carry it, because that was what leading was, and that was what being Yara was, and that was what being a princess was, even if she had never wanted the crown.

She put the sketch down, carefully, beside her bowl, where she could see it in the morning, and she put the charm back in its place, and she lay down, and she slept, and she dreamed, not of snares, and not of the man in the trees, but of a river, and a woman sitting beside it, patient and kind and brave, waiting for a question to come back and be read, and of a trial, waiting in the jungle, three days away, and of a father, somewhere, waiting too, for his daughter to find him.

Three days. That was the truest thing she knew, truer than her fear, truer than her pride. In three days, the trial would be announced, and in the days after that, she would face it, and she would prove herself, or she would not, and the village would know, and she would know, and her mother would know, what she was.

She slept, and the village slept, and the trails were watched, and the east trail was hers, and the river was bright, and the human was gone, and the trial was coming.

End of Chapter 6

Yara met Elena Ruiz by accident at the river, helped her when she was hurt, and brought home a name — Dane Mercer — and a promise. But Jabari has heard, and he has called for Yara's trial, and Oya has agreed: in three days, at the fire, the trial will be announced.

Next: Chapter 7 — The trial is announced, and Yara has three days to prepare for a test Jabari wants to be hard — while Elena watches the river, and Dane Mercer reads his empty line.

Book plan: 20 chapters, about 250 pages — Act 1 is Chapters 1–5, Act 2 is Chapters 6–14, Act 3 is Chapters 15–20. Chapters 1–6 are now written. Series: The Yara Chronicles. Book 1: Daughter of Two Worlds.

Daughter of Two Worlds was written by BiomassFlood, with AI assistance from Luna for drafting and editing. All characters, worldbuilding, and story decisions are the author's own original work.